BOOKS ▼

THE QUIET **DIPLOMAT**

A SHARPLY OBSERVED BIOGRAPHY BRINGS U THANT'S OVERLOOKED LEGACY AND IMPACT ON GLOBAL AFFAIRS BACK INTO FOCUS



PEACEMAKER
U Thant, the United Nations and the Untold Story of the 1960s
by Thant Myint-U
JUGGERNAUT
₹999; 382 pages

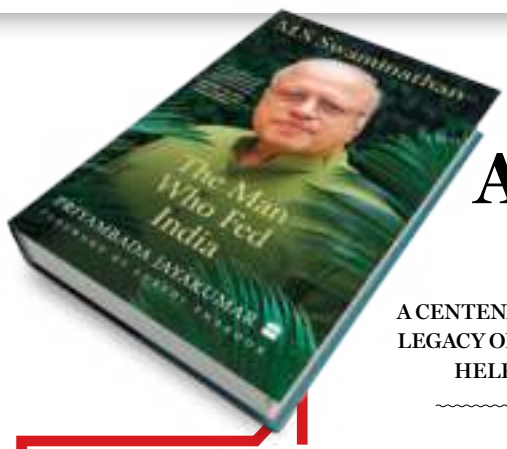
This is not only a fascinating biography of U Thant, the third Secretary-General of the UN, but also an insightful study of the coldest years of the Cold War, from 1961 to 1971. Anchored in deep research and imbued with a judicious mix of empathy and objectivity, the work offers a glimpse of the diverse interactions among the high and mighty of the world in that era, struggling to address the challenges of East–West relations, issues of war and peace and, indeed, the future of our planet.

U Thant was an unconventional UN chief, the first non-westerner to hold this exalted position, which he occupied for a decade. A schoolmaster in a backwater town of the Irrawaddy Delta in Burma until the age of 40, he became a civil servant in Rangoon and then moved to

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An Evergreen Figure

A CENTENARY TRIBUTE THAT CHARTS THE SWEEPING LEGACY OF M.S. SWAMINATHAN, THE SCIENTIST WHO HELPED STEER INDIA AWAY FROM HUNGER



M.S. SWAMINATHAN
THE MAN WHO FED INDIA
By Priyambada Jayakumar
HARPERCOLLINS
₹799; 324 pages

This biography marks the birth centenary of India's most celebrated agricultural scientist, M.S. Swaminathan (MSS; 1925-2023). The author Priyambada Jayakumar, a historian by training, had privileged access to MSS; her mother and the scientist were first cousins. This brings an up close-and-personal feel to the book's opening.

The idea for the book emerged during the pandemic, as much from the frustration of being boxed in as a response to the humanitarian crisis in general and the lack of access to food in particular. MSS himself was driven to agricultural science by another crisis—the Bengal famine of 1943.

The book is broken into 10 chapters, each describing a phase of his life. The volume summarises large events, spread out over long periods and across multiple actors, in a way that readers can easily negotiate. In that, it does a service in bringing to us a life that shaped the history of our nation.

MSS played a primary role in rescuing India from hunger, famine and humiliation in the 1960s, when India was reduced to begging the US for shipments of foodgrain. He recognised the extraordinary yield potential of short-stalk wheat strains bred in Mexico by Norman Borlaug. MSS, along with the agriculture minister C. Subramaniam, championed a turnaround; by 1971, India was self-sufficient in foodgrain, with numerous far-reaching consequences. The book captures all this succinctly, in measured detail.

The 11-page references seem thin, however. The text aims to excite and engage. If you like your prose peppered with adjectives and adverbs, you will enjoy this tract. Nary a page goes by without emphasising the impact of MSS's work, or the scale of his greatness. The prologue calls MSS "possibly the most significant Indian since Gandhi".

No career this long can be free of criticism. MSS has a string of critics, including serious scholars; if he gets the credit for the benefits of the Green Revolution, they say, he should also share the discredit for the agrarian crisis linked to that intervention. The book is rather thin on this aspect, which is unfortunate. We should be able to treat our public figures with more maturity. A man of MSS's stature deserves no less. ■

—Sopan Joshi